GUIDE

Precision Sewing & Patternmaking Guide

From the flat pattern to a finished corset



SIGNATURE CORSET

In this guide

Welcome to Precision Sewing and Patternmaking

Part 1: Materials and Why Each One Matters

Part 2: The Anatomy of a Corset

Part 3: How to Read a Pattern

Part 4: Preparing Your Fabric

Part 5: Marking and Transferring

Part 6: The Construction Sequence, Step by Step

Part 7: Precision Sewing Techniques

Part 8: Basic Corset Patternmaking from Measurements

Part 9: Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

Part 10: Quality Checklist

A Word on Licensing and Selling

Next step

Welcome to Precision Sewing and Patternmaking

> *A corset is a garment of small distances. A quarter inch of drift in a seam, a channel that is slightly too narrow, a grommet set a little off the line: each is invisible on its own, and together they decide whether a corset sits beautifully or fights you at every fitting. This guide teaches the old-world habit of working carefully, so that every pattern in your collection turns out the way it was drawn.*

Everything here is written in inches, with centimeters in parentheses only where they genuinely help. The guide is organized in the order you will use it: materials and tools first, then the anatomy of a corset, then reading and preparing a pattern, then the full construction sequence, then precision techniques, and finally the basics of patternmaking so you can adapt any pattern to your own design.

Every corset in this collection is designed as a **fashion garment**: a costume, a statement piece, a wedding or stage layer, a beautiful object. Nothing here is about reshaping the body, and nothing in this guide is medical advice. Make it to fit you comfortably, and enjoy the craft.

> **The one rule that saves the most fabric**
>
> Always make a test garment (a muslin, also called a toile) in inexpensive fabric before cutting your final fabric. It costs a few hours and a little cotton, and it will save you from ruined coutil, wasted lace and a lot of disappointment.

Part 1: Materials and Why Each One Matters

Corsetry is structural sewing. Unlike a dress, where fabric hangs, a corset has to hold its shape under tension without stretching, bunching or tearing. Each material has one clear job. When you understand the job, choosing a substitute becomes easy and mistakes become rare.

Coutil and structural fabrics

Coutil is a tightly woven, usually herringbone or twill cotton made specifically for corsetry. Its dense weave does not stretch on the bias and does not let the ends of steel bones poke through. It is the traditional choice for the strength layer, the layer that carries the tension of the lacing.

If you cannot find coutil, a good alternative is a firm, tightly woven cotton twill or canvas, around 8 to 10 oz per square yard. Avoid anything with give: stretch denim, loose-weave linen, or soft quilting cotton will all distort under tension. Hold the fabric up to the light and tug it on the bias; if it moves easily, it is not structural enough.

Strength layer, fashion fabric and lining

Most corsets are built from layers, and each layer has its own job. The **strength layer** (coutil or twill) does the work. The **fashion fabric** is the visible outer layer: satin, brocade, cotton sateen, lace over a base, velvet or any beautiful fabric. The **lining** is the layer next to the skin: smooth cotton or cotton batiste is the most comfortable and breathable choice.

LAYER	JOB	GOOD CHOICES	AVOID
Strength layer	Carries tension; stops stretch	Coutil, firm cotton twill, canvas	Stretchy or loose-weave fabric
Fashion fabric	The visible beauty	Satin, brocade, sateen, velvet, lace on a base	Very slippery fabric without a base layer
Lining	Comfort next to the skin	Cotton batiste, light cotton twill	Scratchy or non-breathable fabric
Interlining (optional)	Adds body and hides the bone lines	Cotton flannel or light cotton canvas	Thick fusible products that crack

A fashion fabric that is delicate, stretchy or sheer should always be **flat-lined**: backed with a layer of strength fabric and cut and sewn together as one. The strength layer then carries the load and the delicate fabric just looks lovely.

Boning: spiral steel and flat steel

Bones keep the corset's lines clean and prevent it from wrinkling or collapsing. There are two main types, and they do different jobs.

- **Spiral steel** is a coil of flat wire that flexes in two directions, front to back and side to side. It is ideal for curved seams and for areas that need to move with the body, such as the hip curve. It comes in widths of 1/4 in (6 mm) and 3/16 in (5 mm) and is sold by the foot with separate metal tips.
- **Flat steel** is a rigid strip that bends only front to back. It is used at the center back beside the grommets, next to the busk, and in straight seams where firm support is needed. Common widths are 1/4 in (6 mm) and 3/8 in (10 mm).

Cut bones about 3/8 in (1 cm) shorter than the finished channel on each end, then cap the ends. Capped ends protect your fabric: a bare cut end of steel will wear through a channel in a few wearings. Cheap plastic bones are fine for a costume worn once, but they bend and warp with body heat and are not recommended for a corset you will wear often.

> **Safety with boning**
>
> Steel bones can have sharp ends. Wear snug glasses or eye protection when cutting spiral steel with bolt cutters or heavy wire cutters, because small pieces can fly. File or cap every cut end before it goes near fabric.

Busk

The busk is the two-part front closure made of flat steel studs on one side and loops on the other. It lets you put the corset on without unlacing the back. Choose a busk about 1 to 2 in (2.5 to 5 cm) shorter than the center front length of your finished corset, and make sure the studs and loops are rust-resistant. Busks come in standard and wide-form styles; the wide style is better for a fuller bust.

Grommets and eyelets

Grommets are metal rings, in two pieces, that reinforce the holes the lacing passes through. Size 00 (about 3/8 in or 10 mm) is the standard for corsets. They are stronger and cleaner than hand-sewn eyelets. Use two-part grommets with a washer; one-piece eyelets pull out of fabric far too easily.

Lacing

Corset lacing is a flat cord or ribbon, not a round shoelace. Flat lacing, about 3/8 in (10 mm) wide and made of nylon, cotton or satin ribbon, lies smoothly across the back and does not dig in. You need about 3 to 4 yards (2.7 to 3.7 m) for a typical corset, but measure your grommet rows and add 40 in (100 cm) to be safe.

Bias binding

Bias binding finishes the top and bottom edges. Cut on the diagonal, it curves around the edge without wrinkling. Use a double-fold cotton bias tape about 1 in (25 mm) wide, or make your own from the fashion fabric for a matching look. Binding also adds a thin layer of strength along edges that would otherwise fray.

Waist tape

The waist tape is a length of strong, non-stretch cotton twill tape or petersham, about 3/4 in (20 mm) wide, sewn inside the corset at the waistline. It is the quiet hero of corsetry: it takes the horizontal strain so the seams do not have to, and it stops the corset from stretching at the waist.

Thread and needles

- **Thread:** Use a strong polyester or cotton-wrapped polyester thread, size 40 to 50. Cheap thread breaks under tension. Match the thread color to the fabric for the structural seams, and use a heavy-duty or button thread for the grommet area if you handstitch anything.
- **Machine needles:** A size 90/14 (denim or universal) needle for coutil and several layers; a size 70/10 or 80/12 for lace, silk and fine satin. A dull needle makes skipped stitches and snags, so change it at the start of each project.
- **Hand needles:** A sharp (size 7 or 8) for hand finishing, and a larger sharp for sewing through busks and bindings.

Essential tools

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	WHY IT MATTERS
Tailor's chalk or marking pencil	Transfers pattern marks to fabric	Marks need to be visible but removable; chalk wheels give the finest line
Clapper (pressing block)	Hardwood block pressed on a steamed seam	Holds heat and moisture to give a crisp, flat seam without scorching
Awl	Makes holes for grommets and pokes out corners	A clean hole cuts fewer threads than scissors

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	WHY IT MATTERS
Pliers (flat-nose or jewelry pliers)	Closes bone tips and cinches busk loops	Prevents slipped tips that tear the channel
Grommet setter and anvil	Sets two-part grommets	The right size setter gives a uniform, secure ring
Fabric shears and small snips	Cuts fabric cleanly and clips curves	Dedicated fabric shears stay sharp; paper dulls them
Seam ripper	Removes stitches without damaging fabric	Mistakes happen; a good ripper saves fabric
Measuring tape and clear ruler	Accuracy in measuring and drafting	A 2 in by 18 in clear ruler is the most useful pattern tool
Zipper foot	Stitches close to the bone channel	Lets you sew right beside a bone without catching it
Iron with steam and pressing cloth	Presses seams	Protects delicate fabrics from shine

Tool safety

Keep pins and needles in a magnetic dish, not loose on the table. Unplug the iron when you step away, keep your fingers out of the line of the sewing machine needle, and always hold pliers and awls pointing away from your body. When using a grommet setter, strike with a rubber or leather mallet on a firm, stable surface.

Part 2: The Anatomy of a Corset

Before you cut anything, learn the vocabulary. These parts appear in every pattern of the collection, and knowing their names will make the instructions much easier to follow.

PART	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT MATTERS
Panels	The vertical pieces that make up the body of the corset, numbered from the center front outward	Each panel carries a share of your measurement; the panel shapes create the curves
Seam allowance	The extra fabric beyond the stitching line, normally 5/8 in (1.5 cm)	Gives room to sew, press and adjust. Consistent allowance is the base of precision
Boning channels	Narrow tunnels, usually 3/8 to 1/2 in (10 to 13 mm) wide, that hold the bones	Cut too tight and the bone will not slide in; too wide and it shifts
Waist tape	Twill tape sewn at the waistline inside the corset	Takes the strain off the seams
Busk	Two-part closure at center front	Lets you put on the corset without unlacing

PART	WHAT IT IS	WHY IT MATTERS
Lacing panels	The two back pieces that hold the grommets	Reinforced with flat steel bones; adjusted by the lacing
Modesty panel	A strip of fabric behind the back opening	Prevents skin or undergarments showing through the lacing gap; can be a separate piece sewn to one side
Bust gores	Small, wedge-shaped pieces added to give cup space	Let the corset curve outward over the bust without distortion
Hip gores	Wedge-shaped pieces added below the waist	Allow the corset to flare over the hip
Top edge	The upper edge of the corset, shaped by the neckline design	Finished with binding; may be straight, curved, sweetheart or plunging
Bottom edge	The lower edge, usually at or just below the hip	Finished with binding; can be straight, curved or tabbed
Center front (CF)	The middle front line, where the busk goes	Reference line for symmetry
Center back (CB)	The middle back line, where the lacing goes	Reference line for symmetry

Most patterns in the collection use between 6 and 14 panels. Fewer panels give a simpler corset; more panels allow finer shaping because each seam adds a place for a curve. A typical eight-panel corset, for example, has four panels on each side of center front, with the center-front piece beside the busk and the back pieces holding the grommets.

Part 3: How to Read a Pattern

Every pattern in the collection uses the same set of markings. Take five minutes to learn them and you will be able to work from any piece in the book.

MARK	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT IT MEANS
Cutting line	Solid outer line	Where you cut the fabric. Includes seam allowance when the pattern says so
Stitching line	Dashed line, 5/8 in inside the cutting line	Where the machine stitches. Your stitching must follow this line precisely
Grainline	Long straight line with an arrow at each end	Must run parallel to the fabric's lengthwise grain (the selvage)
Notches	Small triangles or short lines on the edge	Match them to the notches on the adjoining piece. Single, double or triple groups tell panels apart

MARK	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT IT MEANS
Balance marks	Small circles or dots inside the piece	Mark the waist line, bust point or the start and end of a bone channel
Waist line	Horizontal line marked WL	Where the waist tape sits; line up across all panels
Bust line	Horizontal line marked BL	Where the fullest part of the bust sits
Hip line	Horizontal line marked HL	Where the fullest part of the hip sits
CF and CB	Letters on the edge	Center front and center back. A piece cut on the fold has the CF marked on the fold line
Cut on fold	A bracket and arrow pointing at one edge	Place that edge exactly on the fold of the fabric

> **Cutting lines versus stitching lines**
>
> Some patterns are printed with seam allowance already included (cutting lines), and some are printed without (stitching lines). Check the first page of each pattern. The default across this collection is 5/8 in (1.5 cm), but if a pattern says no seam allowance is included, you must add it before cutting. The section on patternmaking explains how.

Before you start, print at 100 percent scale (no fit-to-page), measure the test square on the first page with a ruler, and confirm it is exactly 2 in by 2 in. If it is off, your printer is scaling the file and every piece will be wrong. Tape the sheets together carefully, matching the alignment marks, and check that long seam lines are smooth and not jagged at the joins.

Part 4: Preparing Your Fabric

Preshrink everything

Cotton and linen shrink. A corset that shrinks after the final wash is wasted time. Wash and dry your coutil, lining and any cotton fashion fabric the way you plan to launder the finished corset. Corsets are usually spot-cleaned or hand-washed, so a gentle wash and a steam press is often enough. Silk and satin are normally steamed or dry-cleaned, so treat them accordingly and test a scrap.

Straighten the grain

Fabric is woven from threads running lengthwise (warp, parallel to the selvage) and crosswise (weft). Lengthwise grain has the least stretch, so a corset's vertical panels are always cut with the grainline running up and down. If the cut edge of your fabric is crooked, pull a single crosswise thread to find the true line and trim along it, or tear cotton gently across the width.

Press the fabric flat before cutting. A wrinkle folded into a piece becomes a distorted panel.

Layout

Lay the fabric on a large flat surface with the selvages together, right sides facing in. Arrange pattern pieces so all grainlines are parallel to the selvage. Measure from the grainline arrow to the selvage at both ends of the arrow: the two measurements must match within 1/16 in. Corset panels are usually cut in pairs (left and right), so flip pieces as needed and cut the second piece in a mirrored position.

- Cut every layer (strength, fashion, lining) with the pieces facing the same direction so nap or patterns line up.
- For fabrics with a nap or a one-way print, all pieces must run the same way.
- If you are using stripes or a pattern, match the design at the seams and at the center front before you cut.

Cutting with precision

Use sharp shears and cut with long, even strokes. Keep the lower blade on the table and keep the fabric flat as you cut. Never lift the fabric off the table to cut it, which distorts the shape. For slippery fabrics, pin through tissue paper or use pattern weights instead of pins, and cut single layers rather than folded.

Cut the notches as short snips of 1/8 in (3 mm) or draw them in with chalk. Avoid cutting deep notches in the seam allowance of a structural layer, because deep snips weaken the seam.

> **Plan the cut for 5/8 in margins**
> Leave at least 1 in (2.5 cm) between pieces on the fabric. A little extra margin gives you room to rotate a piece if you see a flaw.

Part 5: Marking and Transferring

Accurate marking is half of precision sewing. In a corset, the points that matter most are the notches, the waist line, the ends of every boning channel and the grommet positions.

- **Tailor's chalk or wax:** Quick, visible and brushes off. Best for the outside of the fabric.
- **Tracing wheel and carbon paper:** Good for transferring stitching lines to the strength layer. Use water-soluble carbon on delicate fabrics.
- **Thread tracing:** Hand-basting a line with contrasting thread. Slow but it leaves no mark, so it suits silk, velvet and satin.
- **Pins:** Push a pin straight through the pattern and fabric at a dot, then mark the fabric on both sides. Useful for balance marks.
- **Washable fabric markers:** Test on a scrap first. Some are permanent on satin.

Mark the waist line, every boning channel position, the busk position, the grommet rows and every notch on the wrong side of each strength layer piece. If you mark on the right side of the fashion fabric, keep marks light and test removal on a scrap.

Label every piece

Use a scrap of masking tape on each piece and write the panel number and the word Left or Right. After cutting eight to twelve nearly identical shapes, it is very easy to sew the wrong pieces together.

Part 6: The Construction Sequence, Step by Step

There are many valid ways to build a corset. The method below is a reliable approach for a lined, boned corset with a busk and back lacing, and it works for every pattern in the collection. Read through the whole sequence before beginning.

Set your machine first

Use a straight stitch of 2.0 to 2.5 mm (about 10 to 12 stitches per inch) for structural seams. Shorter stitches are stronger but are harder to remove. Test on a scrap of the same layers you will be sewing.

Step 1: Sew the panels together

Start with the strength layer. Pin the first two adjoining panels with right sides together, matching the notches and the waist marks. Pin at right angles to the seam, with pin heads toward the raw edge, so you can sew over them slowly or remove them just before the needle.

Stitch with a 5/8 in (1.5 cm) seam allowance along the stitching line. Start and end with a backstitch of about 1/2 in. Sew panels in order from center front to center back, then join each completed side. Always sew from the wide part to the narrow part, or from the waist outward, so that the grain does not twist.

Do the same for the fashion fabric and the lining, keeping the pieces separate for now. If you are flat-lining, treat the fashion fabric and strength layer as a single layer and baste them together 3/8 in from the cut edge before sewing.

Step 2: Press the seams

After each seam, press it flat as sewn to set the stitches. Then press it open or to one side, depending on the design:

PRESSING METHOD	WHEN TO USE IT	RESULT
Press seams open	When the seam will be covered by a boning channel on top of the seam, or when you want the least bulk	Flat and smooth; bones are inserted in a separate channel
Press seams to one side	When the bone is placed in a channel formed by the seam allowances (the seam itself becomes the channel)	The two seam allowances form a tunnel for the bone

Press from the wrong side, using steam, then lay the clapper on the seam until it cools. This sets a crisp, flat seam. On curved seams, press over a tailor's ham or a rolled towel so the curve is preserved.

Clip curves where the seam allowance is on the inside of a curve (so it can open out) and notch where the allowance is on the outside of a curve (so it can lie flat). Cut up to, but not through, the stitching, leaving at least 1/16 in (1.5 mm).

Step 3: Make the boning channels

There are two common ways to make boning channels. Pick whichever the pattern calls for, or whichever suits your fabric.

- **Seam channels:** Press both seam allowances to one side, then topstitch 3/8 in (10 mm) away from the seam on the fashion side, catching both allowances. The bone slides into the tunnel formed by the allowances. This is fast and neat but the channel is only as wide as the allowance.
- **Applied channels:** Sew bone casing tape, or strips of cotton twill cut on the straight grain 1 in (25 mm) wide, onto the inside of the strength layer. Fold under the long edges 1/4 in each side, then stitch 1/16 in from each edge. The channel should be 1/16 in wider than the bone.

Use a zipper foot and sew as close to the bone as you can. Check that every channel is the same width by sliding a spare bone through it. Mark the end of each channel with a bar tack so the bone cannot slip out, and so the stitching does not unravel.

> **Leave bones out until the end of the sewing**
>
> Do not insert the bones until all machine stitching is done. A needle hitting a steel bone will break the needle, and a broken needle can fly. Make a habit of checking that every bone is out of the way before you stitch near a channel.

Step 4: Insert the busk

The busk is set into the center front panels. Lay the two center-front pieces right sides up with the stitching line marked on each. Mark the studs on the left piece (the stud side) and the loops on the right piece. The studs go through the fabric; the loops sit in cut slits.

1. Cut small round holes with an awl in the stud side, at the exact marks. Do not cut, push the awl between the threads and widen the hole gently.
2. Reinforce the loop side with a strip of strong interfacing or extra twill fused behind the busk area.
3. Cut small slits for the loops, not wider than the loop itself, then thread each loop through.
4. Check that the studs pass through the loops with the two panels edge to edge. If the busk is too tight or too loose, it will pull. Adjust by moving the stud side in or out 1/8 in.
5. Sew a casing or a flat steel bone alongside the busk so the busk edge cannot bend.

Finally, fold the center-front edges over and stitch close to the busk, using a zipper foot, so the fabric lies snug against the metal.

Step 5: Attach the lining

Place the lining over the strength layer and fashion fabric, right sides together, and stitch along the top and bottom edges, or as the pattern directs. Turn right side out through the center back opening, then press carefully. Understitch if the pattern calls for it (see the precision techniques section) so that the lining does not roll to the outside.

If you are using the "bag" method, the corset and its lining are sewn as separate shells, then joined along the edges. Leave the center-back edges open for the lacing panels.

Step 6: Sew the waist tape

Cut a piece of waist tape about 2 in (5 cm) longer than the finished waist measurement of the corset. Mark the waist line on the strength layer. Place the tape along the line, centered on the marks, and stitch along both long edges, keeping the stitching straight and parallel to the waist line.

Keep the tape flat and unstretched. If the tape is sewn too tight, the waist will pucker; too loose, and it will not do its job. The ends of the tape should be turned under 1/2 in and stitched into the center back seam.

Step 7: Insert the bones

Cut each bone to length: 3/8 in (1 cm) shorter than the channel at each end, plus the tip. Cap the ends of spiral steel with metal tips, crimped firmly with pliers, then check that nothing wobbles. For flat steel, round the corners with a file or grinder and dip in plastic coating, or cover with a strip of tape.

Slide each bone into its channel gently. Never force it. If a bone sticks, take it out and check the channel width. Close the channel at the top with a bar tack of about 5 stitches.

Step 8: Set the grommets

Mark the grommet positions on the lacing panels. For a standard back, use grommets spaced 3/4 in (2 cm) apart, with about 1/2 in (13 mm) between the center-back edge and the center of the first grommet, and a closer pair of grommets at the waist line (about 1/2 in apart) to form the waist loop if the pattern includes one.

1. Make a hole at each mark using an awl or a hole punch, not scissors.
2. Insert the post of the grommet from the right side, place the washer over it on the wrong side.
3. Place the setter over the post and strike firmly with a mallet on a hard surface, one or two sharp blows.
4. Test one grommet on a scrap of your layers first. If the grommet spins, strike again; if the rim cracks, you struck too hard.
5. Check that all grommets are the same distance from the edge, using a ruler as a guide.

> **Prevent tear-out**
>
> Make sure the lacing panels are reinforced with two layers of strength fabric and a flat steel bone on either side of the grommet row. A grommet set in a single layer will pull out under tension.

Step 9: Bind the edges

Bias binding gives the final, neat finish. Cut bias strips 1 3/4 in (4.5 cm) wide for a finished binding of about 1/2 in (13 mm), or use ready-made double-fold tape. Join strips with diagonal seams, pressed open.

1. Trim the raw edges of the corset so all layers are even. Baste the layers together 1/4 in from the edge.
2. With right sides together, pin the binding to the right side of the corset along the edge, matching the raw edges.
3. Stitch 1/4 in from the edge, easing the binding gently around curves. Do not stretch the binding.
4. Press the binding up and away from the corset, then fold it to the inside, enclosing the raw edges. The fold should just cover the stitching line.
5. Stitch in the ditch (the seam line) from the right side, or slipstitch the fold by hand for an invisible finish.
6. Where binding meets the center-back edge, fold the end under 1/2 in and stitch it neatly.

Take your time on curves. Binding that is pulled tight will make the top edge curl; binding that is too loose will ripple. Press as you go.

Step 10: Add the lacing

Thread the lacing through the grommets. The simplest method is straight lacing, in which the lace is threaded criss-cross from top to bottom with the two ends emerging at the top. For a corset with a waist loop, thread from the top down to the waist, leave a loop on each side at the waist, and then continue to the bottom.

Wear the corset on the first trial with a thin layer beneath it. Lace as snugly as is comfortable and no more. Fashion corsets are not designed to be tightly closed. If you feel pain, pinching, or difficulty breathing, loosen it right away. This guide is not medical advice; if you have any health concerns about wearing a corset, consult a qualified professional.

Part 7: Precision Sewing Techniques

Stay-stitching

Stay-stitching is a single line of regular stitching sewn through one layer, just inside the seam allowance (about 1/2 in from the edge), on curved or bias edges. It stops the fabric stretching before you join it to another piece. Stay-stitch every curved edge, such as the top edge, the bust curve and the hip curve, directly after cutting.

Always stay-stitch in the direction of the grain, from the wide part of the piece to the narrow part, so the threads are not pushed out of line.

Understitching

Understitching keeps a lining from rolling to the outside. After sewing the lining to the fashion layer and trimming, press the seam allowances toward the lining. Then stitch on the lining side, about 1/16 in from the seam, catching the allowances. The stitching is not visible from the outside, and the lining stays hidden.

Trimming and grading

Where multiple seam allowances lie on top of each other, trim each layer to a different width to reduce bulk. This is called grading. Trim the layer closest to the skin the longest (about 5/8 in), the next layer to 1/2 in, and the layer nearest the outside to 3/8 in. This gives a smooth, stepped edge that does not show through.

Notching and clipping curves

CURVE TYPE	WHAT TO DO	WHY
Convex (curves outward, like the top of the bust)	Cut small V-shaped notches about 1/4 in apart, removing a wedge	The outer edge is longer and needs room to lie flat
Concave (curves inward, like the waist)	Make straight clips about 1/4 in apart, up to but not through the stitching	The edge needs to spread to lie flat

Always cut just short of the stitching line, leaving at least 1/16 in. A clip that goes through the stitching will fray and weaken the seam.

Pressing

Pressing, not ironing, is the secret of a professional finish. Pressing means lowering and lifting the iron, not sliding it, which can distort curved and bias pieces. Press every seam as you go: first flat as sewn, then open or to the side, always from the wrong side. For delicate fabrics, use a pressing cloth and the right temperature setting. Test on a scrap before every new fabric.

> **Iron safety**
>
> Always rest the iron on its heel, never face down. Keep the cord clear of your work area and out of reach of children and pets. Steam burns are real: lift the iron away from yourself, and keep your free hand clear of the steam as you lift a pressing cloth.

Sewing straight and accurate seams

- Use the 5/8 in line on your machine's needle plate, or stick a piece of masking tape at that distance as a guide.
- Keep your eyes on the guide line, not the needle.
- Sew slowly on curves, and pivot with the needle down if you need to correct your direction.
- Use an even foot pressure. A walking foot helps when sewing several layers.
- If you are off by more than 1/16 in, unpick and re-sew. Small errors in a corset compound.

Part 8: Basic Corset Patternmaking from Measurements

Every pattern in the collection has been drafted, graded and tested. But understanding how a corset pattern is built lets you adapt any design to your own body and style. This section is an introduction: the

principles are simple, and a little practice goes a long way.

Taking measurements

Wear the thin layer you will wear under the corset. Use a flexible tape measure, keep it parallel to the floor and snug but not tight. Have a friend help if you can.

MEASUREMENT	WHERE TO TAKE IT	NOTES
Underbust	Around the ribcage just under the bust	Sets the top edge for most corsets
Bust	Around the fullest part of the bust	Used for corsets with cups or bust gores
Natural waist	Around the narrowest part of the torso, usually 1 in above the belly button	Where the waist tape sits
High hip	Around the body about 3 to 4 in below the waist	Marks the start of the hip curve
Low hip	Around the fullest part of the hips	Sets the bottom width, if the corset extends over the hip
Torso length, front	From the underbust down to the desired bottom edge	Determines the corset height at center front
Torso length, back	From the same level at the back to the bottom edge	Usually 1 in longer than the front
Waist to underbust	Vertical distance from natural waist up to the underbust	Positions the waist line in the pattern
Waist to low hip	Vertical distance from the waist down to the low hip	Sets the length of the lower part

Write the measurements down, in inches, and compare them with the size chart on the first page of the pattern you are adapting. The chart gives each size (XS to 2XL) with the target measurements.

Distributing the circumference among the panels

A corset is cut in panels, and each panel receives a share of the total circumference. A good corset is slightly smaller than the body at the waist, with a small gap at the back (usually 2 to 3 in) where the lacing sits. This gap allows you to adjust the corset for comfort. Here is a basic method for a six-panel half-pattern.

1. Start with the finished waist measurement of the corset. For a fashion corset, make it equal to your waist measurement, or up to 2 in smaller if you want a gentle shaping. For example, with a 30 in waist, the finished corset waist might be 28 to 30 in.
2. Subtract the back gap (for example 2 in) to find the total width of fabric at the waist, here 26 to 28 in.
3. Divide by 2 to get the half-pattern width, 13 to 14 in.

4. Divide that among the panels. For six panels per half, the front and back panels are often slightly narrower, and the side panels are slightly wider. A common distribution is: panel 1 (CF) 20 percent, panel 2 22 percent, panel 3 (side) 24 percent, panel 4 18 percent, panel 5 and CB 16 percent.
5. Add seam allowance of 5/8 in on each long edge of each panel, plus 5/8 in at the top and bottom edges.

> **Seam allowances do not count toward the finished size**
>
> Distribute the finished measurement among the panels first, then add seam allowance. If you include seam allowance in your calculations, the corset will come out too large.

Drawing the waist curve

Draw a vertical line to represent the center front, then draw horizontal lines at the underbust, waist and low hip levels, spaced according to your vertical measurements. On each horizontal line, mark the width of the panel at that level.

For a panel to follow the body, its width at the bust, waist and hip lines must match the share of the circumference at that level. The width is largest at the bust and hip levels and smallest at the waist. Join the points with a smooth, flowing curve, using a French curve or a flexible ruler. The curve should be gentle and continuous, never angular. Check that the two seams of a panel have similar lengths between the waist line and the hip, or notches will not match.

LEVEL	TYPICAL PANEL WIDTH CHANGE VS. WAIST	EFFECT
Underbust	Wider by 1/2 to 1 in per panel	Allows room for the ribcage
Waist	Narrowest point (baseline)	Defines the waistline
High hip	Wider by 1/4 to 3/4 in per panel	Starts the flare
Low hip	Wider by 3/4 to 1 in per panel	Matches the hips

These are starting values, not rules. Your own measurements are the real guide. Always test the pattern in muslin and adjust.

Determining the length

Mark the top and bottom edges on the center front line, using your torso length measurements. A longer corset (an overbust or a longline) will reach the hip; a shorter one (a waspie or a cincher style) ends just below the waist. Remember that a corset sits comfortably only if the bottom edge clears your hip bone and the top edge clears your underarm. When in doubt, try the muslin and mark the edges directly on your body.

Changing the neckline

Change the top edge to create a different look. Tape the front panels onto a sheet of paper and redraw the top edge. Keep the side seams and back panels the same unless you need to change the height there.

NECKLINE	HOW TO DRAW IT	BEST FOR
Straight	Draw a horizontal line across the top of each panel at the same height	Simple, symmetrical, easiest to bind
Sweetheart	Raise the center-front of each cup into a gentle peak, 1 to 2 in above the straight edge, and curve down to the side	Classic romantic bodice style
Plunge	Lower the center front by 2 to 4 in, and draw a V or deep curve to the sides	Deeper necklines, evening wear
Curved (scoop)	Draw a shallow curve between the sides that dips by 1/2 to 1 in at the center	Soft and understated shape

Whichever shape you choose, make sure the new top edge stays at least 1/2 in below the highest point of the bone channels, so the bones do not poke out. Smooth every new line with a ruler or curve. Then remeasure the new seam lengths and make sure the adjoining pieces still match.

Lengthening and shortening

To change the length of a pattern, use the lengthen and shorten lines. These are horizontal lines drawn across all the panels at the waist, or between waist and hip.

1. Draw a horizontal line across each panel, perpendicular to the center front, at the waist or at the midpoint between the waist and the bottom edge.
2. To lengthen, cut along the line and spread the two pieces apart by the amount you need, for example 1 in. Slip a piece of paper behind and tape.
3. To shorten, fold out the amount on the line, for instance 1/2 in, and tape.
4. Redraw the seam lines to blend the new shape with the original curve.
5. Make the same change on every panel and check that seam lengths still match.

Make length changes between the waist and the bottom edge if you want to keep the waist position the same, and between the underbust and waist if you want to move the waist position. Most people need changes in only one place.

Adding seam allowance

If you draft your own pattern or you start from a pattern printed on the stitching line, you must add seam allowance before cutting.

1. Set your clear ruler at 5/8 in from the stitching line and draw a parallel line all the way around the piece.
2. At corners, extend both lines until they meet, or round them slightly.
3. On sharp curves, draw short segments and smooth them out.
4. Mark the notches on the new edge, extending them through the allowance.
5. Mark the grainline, panel number and 'cut 2' or 'cut 4' on each piece.

Use a different seam allowance only for a reason. Some makers use 1/2 in (12 mm) on the strength layer and a wider allowance for hems and binding. Whatever you choose, use the same amount on every piece and mark it on the pattern.

Making a muslin

Cut your pattern in inexpensive cotton, ideally with a similar weight to coutil. Mark the waist line and the busk position. Sew the panels together with a long basting stitch, set the busk or pin the center front, and lace the back with a ribbon. Try it on over the same layers you plan to wear.

Check the following: the corset sits level, the waist line is at your waist, the bottom edge does not dig into your hips when you sit, the top edge clears your underarms and bust, and the back gap is even from top to bottom. Mark any changes right on the muslin with a pen, take it apart, and transfer the corrections to your paper pattern.

> **Fit comfortably**
>
> A fashion corset should be comfortable to wear for the time you intend. Lace only as snugly as is comfortable. If you feel pain, dizziness, numbness or difficulty breathing, loosen or remove it right away. Nothing in this guide is medical advice.

Part 9: Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW TO AVOID IT
Skipping the muslin	The final corset does not fit and the good fabric is wasted	Always test in cheap cotton first
Printing at the wrong scale	All pieces are too small or too large	Print at 100 percent and measure the test square
Cutting off grain	Panels twist and stretch unevenly	Check the grainline against the selvage at both ends
Inconsistent seam allowance	Panels do not match and the corset is lopsided	Use a seam guide and test the allowance on scrap
Channels too narrow	Bones will not slide in, or they bend	Make channels 1/16 in wider than the bone
Bones too long	Bones poke through the edge	Cut 3/8 in shorter than the channel and cap the ends
Bare bone ends	Wear a hole in the fabric	Always cap or cover cut ends
No waist tape	Seams stretch and the waist loses its shape	Sew a tape at the waist on every corset
Grommets in a single layer	Grommets tear out	Reinforce with two layers and a bone

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS	HOW TO AVOID IT
Pulling the binding	Edges curl or pucker	Ease the binding without stretching
Skipping stay-stitching	Curved edges stretch out of shape	Stay-stitch right after cutting
Pressing with too much heat	Shiny marks or scorching	Test on scrap and use a pressing cloth
Using stretch thread or weak thread	Seams burst	Use strong polyester or cotton-wrapped thread
Lacing too tight	Discomfort and strain	Lace snugly but comfortably; loosen at any discomfort

Part 10: Quality Checklist

Use these checklists before you start, during construction and after the corset is finished. A few minutes of checking can prevent hours of unpicking.

BEFORE YOU CUT

- ☐ Printed at 100 percent and checked the 2 in test square
- ☐ Taped the sheets together with all alignment marks matching
- ☐ Chosen the correct size from the measurement table
- ☐ Made a muslin and adjusted the pattern
- ☐ Preshrunk all fabrics and pressed them flat
- ☐ Checked that the grainline is parallel to the selvage on every piece
- ☐ Marked left and right on each piece with tape

WHILE SEWING

- ☐ Stay-stitched all curved edges
- ☐ Stitched every seam at 5/8 in with consistent tension
- ☐ Matched all notches and waist marks
- ☐ Pressed every seam before crossing it with another seam
- ☐ Clipped and notched curves without cutting through stitching
- ☐ Boning channels are the same width and length
- ☐ Bones are still out of the machine's way

AFTER CONSTRUCTION

- ☐ Waist tape is flat, centered on the waist line and securely stitched
- ☐ Busk lies flat and closes smoothly
- ☐ All bones are capped, inserted and secured at the top
- ☐ Grommets are the same distance from the edge and firmly set
- ☐ Binding is even in width, with no twisting or puckering
- ☐ Lining lies flat and does not roll to the outside
- ☐ No loose threads or stray pins remain
- ☐ Laced the corset on the body and checked the fit and comfort

A Word on Licensing and Selling

Purchasing the collection does not automatically grant resale rights to the digital files. The patterns are for your own use and for making garments. If you plan to sell finished products made from these patterns, check the terms that came with the files before you begin. Nothing in this guide is a guarantee of income or business results, and any sewing business depends on your own skill, costs and market.

Next step

Choose one pattern from the collection, print it at 100 percent, and make a muslin this week. Take your time, follow the construction sequence from Part 6, and use the checklist at the end. Once the muslin fits, cut your good fabric with confidence and enjoy the quiet satisfaction of a well-made corset. Then move on to the bonus guides in your collection for tulle, finishing and photography. Happy sewing.